

A silver between the lines

After eight years of near misses at multi-sport Games, **Elavenil Valarivan** finally won a medal at Nagoya, with a small scrapbook chronicling the journey.

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A silver medal can be a bittersweet achievement. It means you came second. Or, depending on how the competition unfolded, it can leave you wondering how close you came to winning gold.

There was perhaps a hint of that feeling in the first call Elavenil Valarivan made after finishing second in the women's 10m air rifle competition at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games.

"I missed a gold! I was so close!" she told her coach, Neha Chavan, back in Chennai.

It was easy to understand why. The 27-year-old opened with a perfect 10.9 and led for much of the 24-shot final. She kept the Chinese shooters off the podium and pushed Olympic champion Ban Hyo-jin into

third place. Gold had seemed within Elavenil's grasp before a late stumble over the final three shots allowed Japan's Hinata Taichi to move in front and win the title by 0.6 points, 253.0 to 252.4.

But Elavenil's post-match call captured only part of what she was feeling. The rest is written in a scrapbook in which she makes a little note every time she shoots. But more on that later.

Elavenil's medal is no ordinary silver.

You could see that in the beaming smile on her face as she held it up on the podium.

"I have a lot of gratitude. I'm trying to practise saying these words a lot more frequently and I'm just grateful I could win these medals," she told *Sportstar* outside the Aichi

Prefectural General Shooting Gallery.

This was India's first individual medal of the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games. It followed the team silver alongside Vidarsa Vinod and Sonam Maskar that Elavenil had helped secure in the qualification round earlier that morning.

More significantly, both were Elavenil's first medals at a multi-sport Games.

"I've been competing at these multi-event Games for the last eight years. I've finally got my first medals," she said.

When you look at her career, that statistic seems a strange sort of anomaly.

Ever since Olympic medallist Gagan Narang spotted her as a 14-year-old in Ahmedabad, there